
What to Expect After General Anesthesia

The first 24 hours

- Your pet may be **sleepy, weak or wobbly for up to 24 hours**. Most return to normal mobility within a day.
- **Keep your pet off stairs and furniture** and in a quiet, safe area until fully recovered.
- Supervise outdoor potty breaks on a leash.

Food and water

- **4 hours after getting home:** offer $\frac{1}{4}$ of a normal meal.
- Offer **small amounts of water often** over the next 12 hours.
- **Do not let your pet gorge** for 12–24 hours — mild nausea is common after anesthesia.
- Resume normal meals the next day if your pet is eating well.

Common, mild after-effects

- **Mild cough** — from the breathing tube; should improve over 1–3 days.
- **Diarrhea** — feed a bland diet (Hill's i/d, Purina EN, or boiled chicken and rice) until stools are normal, then switch back to the regular diet over several days. If diarrhea is not improving after 2–3 days, call your veterinarian.
- **Constipation** — usually resolves on its own as normal eating returns.
- Mild bruising or redness where the IV catheter or monitoring equipment was placed.

Seek veterinary attention if your pet has

- **Vomiting**
- **Straining** to defecate without producing stool
- **Not eating** by the next day
- A **painful belly**
- Worsening cough, difficulty breathing, or pale gums
- Not back to normal after 24 hours